Missing Natalie and Victim

By Nicole Blackman

INTRODUCTION

Each year, more than 1 million children are reported missing. This is a staggering number, but it doesn't take into account the trauma faced by the overlooked sisters and brothers of those abducted whose family are irrevocably changed. This selection, Missing Natalie by Nicole Blackman brings to life the struggle of one young girl to come to terms with the abduction of her twin sister.

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Missing Natalie

Most of my friends don't know I was born a twin. She was born sixty-three seconds before me. Her name was Natalie. We came here together. She left without me.

We shared a room and split it down the middle. I put all my posters up on my side, and she put hers up on the other. One day we decided to wallpaper the room with Superfriends wrapping paper and Elmer's glue. Mom wasn't too crazy about that.

She was patient, I was bossy. She wanted to be a gymnast, I wanted to be an actress. But we both liked horses and we liked to draw. We mixed up things like ketchup and cough syrup and tried to get someone to eat it. Natalie and I would climb trees in our backyard and plan the houses we would build next to each other so we could visit when we had families of our own. We picked out the names for our husbands, for our children. When you're a twin, you have a shadow.

We were in the supermarket looking at the toys. Mom was picking up some shampoo and cat food. There was a doll that I really wanted so I ran a couple aisles over to ask Mom. She told me I already had too many dolls and sent me back to get Natalie so we could leave the store. It all happened in a minute.

This is the part where I'm supposed to tell you that your life can change forever in sixty-three seconds. But you already know that, don't you?

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On the surveillance camera, you can see Natalie walking out of the store with a man. He's not forcing her, but we don't know why she's going with him. She turns around for a second like she's saying goodbye. At least that's what we think it means.

We've gone over the video hundreds of times. It's burned in my mind like the Zapruder film. Even now I could draw it for you, with the time code on the bottom of the screen and everything. I'm twenty-four now. She's frozen at nine.

When she was gone a month, I put our beds together and put a blanket across them when I slept.

They sent me to a child psychologist for a long time. She made me draw my "feelings." Let's draw your feelings now. What do your feelings look like? I wanted to strangle her. Instead, I drew for an hour so she'd shut up. I used only the black markers and drew me and a burned-out hole for Natalie. That's me, and that's Natalie. The psychologist analyzed the drawings and talked to my parents. She's having a very difficult time. Losing Natalie has left a void in her life. Well, duh. You could have just asked me and saved yourself a lot of time. You want to know how I feel? You want to know what's going on? Someone stole my sister. Someone f***** stole my sister. How many drawings do you want me to make? They stopped making me go to the psychologist after that.

I never saw Dad cry, but something was sacrificed after it happened. He drinks alone now sometimes. He never used to do that.

The police give us a report every three years now or something, and tell us the case is still open, as if that's a help. They try to tell me sometimes that since they never found a body, she might be alive. Right. Like there's nowhere on earth to hide a body. If she was alive, I'd know. If anyone would know I'd know, and I haven't felt her near me in a long, long time.

They put me under hypnosis. I told them the man was wearing a navy-blue corduroy jacket, had brown work boots on, smelled of grease and never looked at me. The case is still open.

Four months after she disappeared, it was our tenth birthday. I told Mom to forget about it but she insisted ... she always had a birthday party for us ... we had to go on with a normal life.

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The day of the party we hung up balloons and streamers and Mom pretended Natalie was away somewhere, like it was a surprise. I sat there and waited. I waited all day.

Nobody came. All the kids who used to come to our parties now said they couldn't. Sometimes their mothers called and cancelled, like abductions were contagious and they didn't want their kids to catch it too.

That night Mom and I sat in the kitchen and ate a box of sugar cookies and talked about Natalie. We didn't have anymore birthday parties after that. It became the birthday ritual. We would eat a whole box of sugar cookies and talk about Natalie for hours. It was our way of keeping her close. We do it every year. Dad still doesn't know.

My parents refused to move after Natalie disappeared. We need to be here when she comes back. Otherwise, how will she find us?

We just want to know what happened. It's like watching a scary movie and the film breaks in the last fifteen minutes and they try to make everyone go home. We just want to know what happened.

Most of my friends don't even know I was born a twin. She was born sixty-three seconds before me. Her name was Natalie. We came here together. She left without me.

TRANSITION

According to the Office of Juvenile Justice and Delinquency Prevention . . . The murder of an abducted child, particularly by a stranger, is a rare event. There are estimated to be about 100 such incidents in the United States each year. The victims are typically "average" children, leading normal lives, and growing up in normal families. Just like Natalie, the vast majority of them are girls, with the average age between 11 and 12 years old. Natalie was just a bit younger. This is her story . . . Victim by Nicole Blackman.

Victim

I feel the motion of the car before I open my eyes. The air is blue-black, brown-black, black-black. Smell of gas, oil, animals.

I'm in the trunk.

My wrists and ankles tied. My mouth is taped

and it almost covers my nose but I can breathe barely.

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I must have been here for hours, everything's stiff and my head throbs like someone's drumming on china.

The car stops.

He turns off the motor - there are no traffic sounds. No people sounds. No wind.

What place has no wind?

I turn my head towards the sounds

like people watch radios when something terrible happens.

My palms are sweating. Where am I?

The trunk squeaks as he lifts it up and the sun blinds me. He almost looks like a faceless Jesus surrounded by light.

He pulls me out of the trunk and bangs my head against the door. I try to cry out, but it comes out like a hum.

He drags me, half-standing, along a dirt road into a house. I can't see any other houses and it looks like a farm.

The screen door bangs behind me

and I feel a deep, deep pressure inside me. All the rules have changed here.

I'm dragged down a hall like a bag and I look for a phone, other doors. Nothing but bare floors and brown boxes in small rooms.

He pulls me into the bathroom

and I almost crack my head as he pushes me onto the floor. Tilts his head to the side

and gazes at me as if I was a pet, then walks out.

I'm lying there for a long time, trying to get the tape off of me. My eyes are tearing. I don't make a sound.

I can't get up and I keep rolling from side to side, trying not to make noise.

I've got to get him to talk to me.

If I can get this thing off my face I can talk to him. I'll tell him my name.

Have you killed other women in here?

I'm thinking that you've got hundreds of them

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nailed down, hung on walls, hanging from ceiling fans and swinging dead in summer wind.

Why did you pick me?

If I had stayed to finish at the library

I would have been there 20 minutes longer maybe I'd have been OK.

Would have rushed into the house,

books piled up in my arms like a baby, and blurted explanations why I was sorry. So sorry I'm late everyone.

Would you have waited for me anyway? Would you have picked another woman?

Would I have read about her in the paper and said Oh my god, I was there that night...

and called all my friends in a panic.

Telling them then how much I loved them

as if I'd never have the chance again.

I wonder what everyone is doing now. Putting up signs. Showing my picture on the evening news. Calling old friends. Maybe I'm not even considered missing yet.

The family will fall apart and my parents will go crazy. Slowly.

My brother will be so quiet at the funeral and insist the casket be closed. (I never even told anyone what kind of funeral I wanted when I died.)

Maybe years from now they'll find my skeleton on the floor here

and they'll have to use dental records to identify me.

My family will say *At least we know now.*

We always hoped she was alive somewhere.

We just hope she's in peace.

When I sleep my dreams are crazy - I'm flying over fields.

I don't think I sleep for more than 20 minutes and when I wake up, it feels like I'm wider a heavy blanket. I'm still here.

As I wake up I hear a dog barking in the distance

and I think I'm in my parents' house in South Carolina.

When I open my eyes, there's a shotgun pressed between them.

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I'll never get married.

I'll never have kids.

I'll never go to Europe.

I'll never learn to play piano. I'll never write a book.

The last thing I hear is a click.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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